

WIRED WARRIORS: The Super-Grunts of Tomorrow

Cutting edge computing technology and breakthroughs in civilian and military technology are going to be powering the war machine of tomorrow. Here come some of the more interesting developments that will fight the wars of the future



As George S Patton, the strategist US General of the Second World War, put it, "...no b***** ever won a war by dying for his country. You win a war by making the other poor dumb b***** die for his country". In a world that has enormous potential for conflict, militaries around the world are taking Patton's words very seriously.

Right from ancient times, the foot soldier has fought and won the battle for the victor. However, over the past decade or so, the infantry's role has changed—the emergence of smart munitions and precision aerial bombardment has resulted in the infantryman entering tough urban combat situations to mop up any remaining resistance.

Blood, guts, cordite...and a computer

Tomorrow's heroic soldier isn't going to jump into battle with just a bullet-proof Kevlar vest, a backpack-sized field radio and a commando knife clutched between his teeth. Researchers are looking to equip soldiers to win wars with fewer casualties. The Land

Warrior System is the first of several such programs that are looking at revamping the infantry soldier's gear. Prototypes that

were developed by several contractors (including Pacific

Consultants and Raytheon), are currently being tested by crack troops of the US Army, at their research facilities at the Natick Soldier Centre in Massachusetts. The progress is being watched with interest by several other countries, and are developing similar systems. The Land Warrior is expected to hit the frontlines somewhere around 2006. The US Army is looking at about 30,000-odd Land Warrior systems joining into service then.

The next generation system that is expected to follow is the Objective Force Warrior, expected to enter service around 2010. The core idea of this is integration of computers, navigation and communication technology with infantry weapons systems, making the individual soldier and the soldier's team a lethal networked tool of war.

The designers of the Land Warrior prototype, and the Objective Force Warrior, have put considerable thought into calculating what is needed to re-inforce today's soldier. They started by strip-